

Lessons for India

Political expediency should not come in the way of national interest

Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf's action against the militants holed up in Lal Masjid in Islamabad may not have a direct impact on India, but it will have strategic consequences. While militants killed in the Lal Masjid siege did not belong to any Kashmiri terrorist outfit, with their gang-ing up against Musharraf, one thing is clear: he will have to face a tough battle for his own survival. Now the General may be forced to take action against militants of all ilks, including those belonging to Kashmiri separatist groups. This may give India some breather, given the rising levels of infiltration from Pakistan, although it cannot afford to lower its guard as Prime Minister Manmohan Singh says Pakistan is finally realising what India has been saying for years—that terrorism is a danger to civilised society.

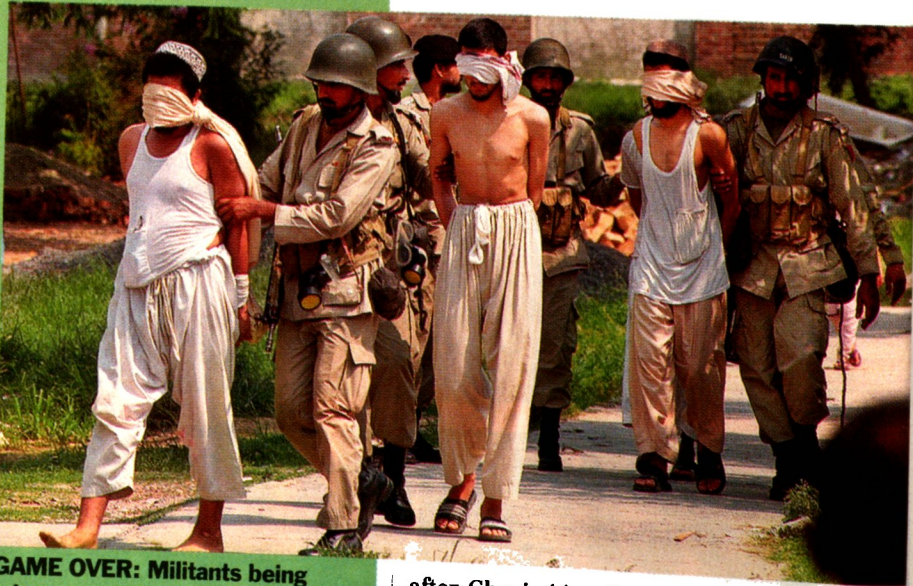
Pakistan's pre-occupation with the developments in Lal Masjid and its fallout may slow down the Indo-Pak peace process. And that is not because of India, but the domestic situation in Pakistan. There might not be much progress on the composite dialogue process as a beleaguered Musharraf will not be in any position to take politically sticky decisions. This would mean that big ticket issues such as Kashmir, Siachen et al will not inch forward. And while the routine talks will go on, substantive outcomes will be hard to come by. Even the Kashmir deal that the two countries were negotiating, is expected to be put on the backburner. The fact that Manmohan Singh has already tasked his special envoy on Pakistan, former diplomat S.K. Lambah to manage economic diplomacy with Singapore, shows there isn't much headway in the Indo-Pak peace talks. While Musharraf's action may deflect attention from the judicial crisis that arose after the suspension of the chief justice earlier this year, the Lal Masjid episode will only tie him down further with domestic issues. With the elections scheduled to take place by the end of the year in Pakistan, his survival is at stake, which is bound to make his position precarious. However, analysts warn India to keep its hands off the current situation in Pakistan. "We are being too cosy with Musharraf, we should widen our options and not do anything which is seen as supporting him," says former Indian envoy to Pakistan G. Parthasarathy. However, the General's gamble, will also ensure that he gets a thumbs up from his Western allies, the US in particular, which would spell a subtle diplomatic setback for India given the fact that there will be few takers for India's argument that Musharraf is not doing enough to curb terrorism. Now, there is a huge silver lining in this. Although critics may blame Musharraf for creating a Pakistani Bluestar, the fact remains that be it a madrasa or a place of worship, no place can be allowed to become a safe haven for militants. It is here that the Indian leadership can take a lesson or two: even though Bluestar kind of operation may not always be the answer, when it comes to the eviction of religious fanatics or terrorists, or curbing their activities, political expediency should not come in the way of protecting national interest.

by Saurabh Shukla

disappointed by the way the Government had reacted to its efforts to "resolve" the standoff.

The Government's mistakes in the entire drama notwithstanding, analysts admit that it exercised the utmost restraint. It kept talking to militants for months and used a variety of channels to reach a settlement. As the Government negotiated with Lal Masjid militants over the past few months, they raided a home, kidnapping three women for allegedly running a brothel, attacked video and music shops, and abducted not only police officers but also eight Chinese nationals. The Government had no option but to retaliate, though the security forces' response on July 3 was essentially low key.

However, the fighting escalated



GAME OVER: Militants being taken away by the Pakistan Army

after Ghazi, 44, refused to show any flexibility to the Government's efforts to wrap-up the operation without any bloodshed. Ghazi's attitude only hardened after his brother Abdul Aziz, who was also the head of the mosque and leader of the masjid movement, was caught last week as he attempted to walk out of the security cauldron wearing a burqa. Ghazi was not by any standards the leading cleric of the radical. He used to move in liberal circles and preferred Western-style clothes as a young man before he turned to religion after the assassination of his father Maulana Abdullah, who founded Lal Masjid, in the 1990s. By storming the mosque, Musharraf has ended the radicals' stronghold in Islamabad but he may just have provoked many more such revolts around the country.